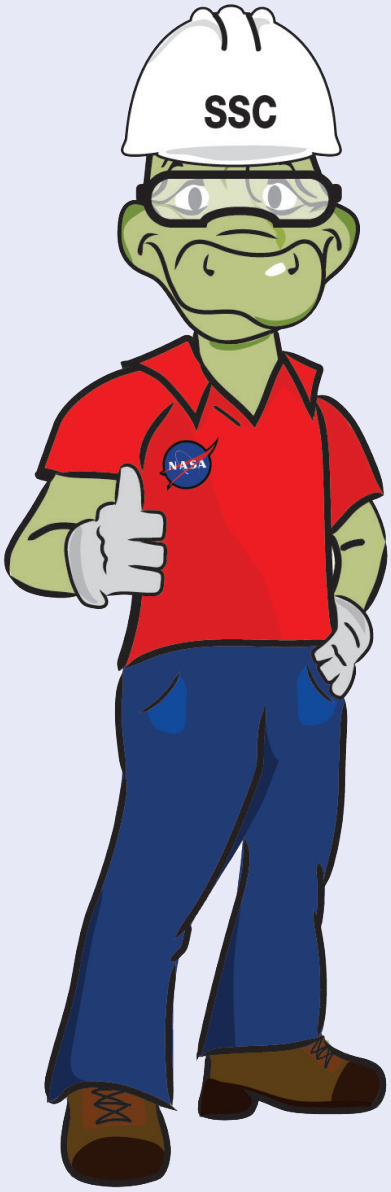
Happy April, folks! I originally came on board in 1965 when NASA Stennis leaders were searching for a mascot to boost employee morale during the early construction days of the site. I have been around a long time but still feel young at heart, primarily because I have been able to interact with great people who work at Stennis, whether it was in 1965 or in 2023.

Pride, dedication, and working with excellence are characteristics that have stood the test of time around here. The last few weeks have been busy for many. I think this month's Lagniappe has all the ingredients for a big ol' pot of inspiration. Now, you might be thinking to yourself, "How did Gator get the inside scoop on Lagniappe?"

As I mentioned earlier, I have been around since 1965, so having connections comes with its perks. Can you say VIG (Very Important Gator)? Ark!

Sometimes, the daily grind makes it difficult to remember how the work completed at NASA Stennis leads to something greater. The various articles and photos in this month's publication are a reminder of that. Take the article that pays tribute to the beginning of the main propulsion test article series for example.



This historic test series began 45 years ago this month at NASA Stennis. Its success pushed NASA forward to the space shuttle era. This opened space to more people than ever during the program's 30 years of missions, including the first American woman in space (Sally Ride) in 1983 and astronauts representing 16 different countries.

The work completed by people at NASA Stennis welcomed this era. Now, NASA continues to inspire the world through discovery through Artemis, which will establish a sustainable presence on the Moon and also land the first woman and first person of color on the lunar surface. The work of countless individuals contributes to the Artemis missions daily.

There is another article in this month's Lagniappe on a longtime employee who worked more than four decades at NASA. I do not want to spoil it for you, but when one is reminded about what work at NASA Stennis leads to, it is understandable why this employee enjoyed every minute of four decades with the agency.

Moving forward with Artemis and other opportunities that will come through the commercialization of space, it recalls the importance of robotics events such as the inaugural Magnolia Regional. I venture to say that many of those participants will play an important role with future STEM-related careers, including some at NASA.

It is my hope that the following pages leave room for all to reminisce on these enjoyable events, to be reminded of how NASA innovates for the benefit of humanity and the role NASA Stennis contributes to that, and finally, to be reinvigorated as we move ahead to future accomplishments.

Lagniappe is published monthly by the Office of Communications at NASA's John C. Stennis Space Center.
Access monthly copies at: www.nasa.gov/centers/stennis/news/publications/index.html
Contact info – (phone) 228-688-3749; (email) ssc-pao@mail.nasa.gov; (mail) NASA OFFICE OF COMMUNICATIONS, Attn: LAGNIAPPE, Mail code IA00, Building 1111 Room 173, Stennis Space Center, MS 39529
Managing Editor – Lacy Thompson Editor – Bo Black Staff Photographer – Danny Nowlin

NASA Names Astronauts to Next Moon Mission, First Crew Under Artemis

NASA and the Canadian Space Agency (CSA) recently announced the four astronauts who will venture around the Moon on Artemis II, the first crewed mission on NASA's path to establishing a long-term presence at the Moon for science and exploration through Artemis. The agencies revealed the crew members April 3 during an event at Ellington Field near NASA's Johnson Space Center in Houston.



The crew of NASA's Artemis II mission (l to r) are: Canadian Space Agency astronaut Jeremy Hansen, and NASA astronauts Victor Glover, Reid Wiseman, and Christina Hammock Koch.

"The Artemis II crew represents thousands of people working tirelessly to bring us to the stars. This is their crew, this is our crew, this is humanity's crew," said NASA Administrator Bill Nelson. "NASA astronauts Reid Wiseman, Victor Glover, and Christina Hammock Koch, and CSA astronaut Jeremy Hansen, each has their own story, but, together, they represent our creed: E pluribus unum – out of many, one. Together, we are ushering in a new era of exploration for a new generation of star sailors and dreamers – the Artemis Generation."

The crew assignments are as follows: Commander Reid Wiseman, Pilot Victor Glover, Mission Specialist 1 Christina Hammock Koch, and Mission Specialist 2 Jeremy Hansen. They will work as a team to execute an ambitious set of demonstrations during the flight test.

The approximately 10-day Artemis II flight test will launch on the agency's powerful Space Launch System rocket, prove the Orion spacecraft's life-support systems, and validate the capabilities and techniques needed for humans to live and work in deep space.

"We are going back to the Moon, and Canada is at the center of this exciting journey," said the Honorable François-Philippe Champagne, the minister responsible for the Canadian Space Agency. "Thanks to our longstanding collaboration with NASA, a Canadian astronaut will fly on this historic mission. On behalf of all Canadians, I want to congratulate Jeremy for being at the forefront of one of the most ambitious human endeavors ever undertaken. Canada's participation in the Artemis program is not only a defining chapter of our history in space, but also a testament to the friendship and close partnership between our two nations."

The flight, set to build upon the successful uncrewed Artemis I mission completed in December, will set the stage for the first woman and first person of color on the Moon through the Artemis program, paving the way for future for long-term human exploration missions to the Moon and, eventually, Mars. This is the agency's Moon to Mars exploration approach.

"For the first time in more than 50 years, these individuals – the Artemis II crew – will be the first humans to fly to the vicinity of the Moon. Among the crew are the first woman, first person of color, and first Canadian on a lunar mission, and all four astronauts will represent the best of humanity as they explore for the benefit of all," said Director Vanessa Wyche, NASA Johnson. "This mission paves the way for the expansion of human deep space exploration and presents new opportunities for scientific discoveries, commercial, industry and academic partnerships and the Artemis Generation."

Through Artemis missions, NASA will use innovative technologies to explore more of the lunar surface than ever before. It will collaborate with commercial and international partners and establish the first long-term presence on the Moon. Then, NASA will use what it learns on and around the Moon to take the next giant leap: sending the first astronauts to Mars.

For more information about the crew, visit here.

Click here to meet the astronauts who will fly around the Moon on Artemis II.

NASA Engineer 'Enjoyed Every Minute' of Four Decades of Service with Agency

Larry Pigott's voice changes as he reflects on his NASA career, his words and tone communicating pride, not surprising considering his career has spanned more than 59 years in the aerospace engineering field, including 42 years as a NASA engineer.

"I would not trade this experience for anything," Pigott said. "I am proud of NASA. I am proud of the people I have worked with over the years."

April marks the official retirement month for the Bogalusa, Louisiana native. No matter how much time has passed, a few things have remained constant throughout Pigott's career – the love for the people he worked with, the teamwork environment associated with the job, and always completing the work in a safe manner.



An image from 2016 shows NASA engineer Larry Pigott at NASA's Stennis Space Center. Pigott will retire in April after 59 years in the aerospace engineering field, including 42 years as a NASA engineer.

Pigott's career with NASA began in 1981, when he spent 11 years at Michoud Assembly Facility in New Orleans. In December 1992, Pigott relocated to NASA's Stennis Space Center, near Bay St. Louis, Mississippi, as a Marshall Space Flight Center technical representative for space shuttle main engines.

He was part of a team that monitored activities associated with an engine testing campaign that, at times included hot fires 24 hours a day for seven days a week.

"I learned working at NASA that to have a good relationship with my fellow workers, it required we trust one another," Pigott said. "Trust is the backbone that holds the team together."

Pigott now splits time living in Pearl River, Louisiana, and Tallahassee, Florida. He describes his most recent work within the Rocket Propulsion Test Program Office at NASA Stennis as insight and oversight that included working with contractors for supporting maintenance and research and development programs.

Pigott's work was a part of something bigger than himself, and the relationships formed along the way were something he valued.

"What makes NASA so special is the fact that they take care of their people," he said. "That's a highlight. That has been proven by a lot of surveys that have taken place that NASA is the best place to work."

An annual national government-wide survey has ranked NASA as the Best Place to Work in the Federal Government, among large agencies, for 11 consecutive years. Pigott said the environment at NASA is different, and the work culture is something that does not happen by accident.

"You have people who enjoy working, especially working together," he said. "They have developed that environment, and they get recognized for the work that is done. Each generation has its way of how they want to run things. As long as you focus on safety, it's going to continue to grow in favorable ways."

While much of Pigott's recent work did not directly involve NASA's Artemis program, he said it is an exciting time in which he sees great opportunities ahead for young engineers as the agency returns humans, including the first woman and the first person of color, to the Moon to explore the lunar surface and prepare for flights to Mars.

"I enjoyed every minute of it," Pigott said about working at NASA. "I love Stennis, and I love the people who work there and look forward to their continuing careers."

Hail & Farewell

NASA bids farewell to:

Larry Pigott	Aerospace Technology	Rocket Propulsion Testing Office

Office of Diversity and Equal Opportunity

Remembering the Holocaust Through the Life of Jeannine Burk

The Holocaust, also called the Shoah, was the systematic, state-sponsored murder of 6 million Jews by Nazi Germany and its collaborators during World War II. It was part of the "Final Solution" – the Nazi plan to annihilate more than 9 million Jews in Europe. The Nazis murdered millions of others as well.

In 1980, The U.S. Congress established Days of Remembrance as the nation's annual commemoration of the Holocaust. The 2023 Holocaust Days of Remembrance, observed April 16-23, is a time to honor and remember the victims of the Holocaust and their liberators.

NASA's Stennis Space Center and the NASA Shared Services Center Office of Diversity and Equal Opportunity remembers and shares the life of Jeannine Burk. She served as guest speaker for the Days of Remembrance Program at NASA Stennis in 2010, where she shared her experiences as a Holocaust survivor. View a video of the 2010 program here.

Two days before Hitler invaded Poland, Jeannine (Rasalowicz) Burk was born in Brussels, Belgium, on September 15, 1939. She was the youngest of three children born to Isaac and Sarah Rasalowicz. Her older brother, Max Rasalowicz, was born in 1930, and Augusta Rasalowicz, her older sister, was born in 1931. When Burk was 3 years old, her father took her to an ally's house where she spent the next two years in hiding.

"My father took me on a streetcar," she recalled in an oral history interview to the Holocaust survivor organization. "This memory is etched in my mind because it was the last time I ever saw my father. We rode to the end of the line. I remember getting off with him. I remember walking what appeared to me to be a long distance. He knocked on a door, and a woman answered. I went inside. That was the last time I ever saw my father."

While never mistreated, Burk shared she never felt loved or supported by the family she stayed with thereafter. She was occasionally allowed to go in the backyard to play but was never allowed to go out in the front yard. Burk remembers hiding in an outhouse from Nazi soldiers when they paraded the street.

"I was petrified," she said in the oral history interview. "An outhouse is small, and I would retreat to the farthest little corner. There was a crack in the front of the outhouse. I thought if I could see them parading outside, they would be able to see me."

After liberation by Allied Forces in 1944, Burk's mother brought her home, where she learned the fate of the rest of her family. While she was in hiding, a neighbor reported the family to the Gestapo, resulting in a raid of their home. Burk's father was taken and eventually sent to Auschwitz, where he perished in the gas chamber. Burk's mother and sister were left when the Gestapo discovered her older sister in a body cast due to her bone disease, osteomyelitis. Her brother was hiding in a Christian home for boys. During the aftermath, Burk's mother took her sister to a Catholic hospital where she stayed in the isolation ward for two years. Her mother found solace in a nursing home where she worked as a practical nurse.

In 1950, Burk's mother died of breast cancer when the younger girl was only 10 years old. In the wake of her mother's death, Burk and her older sister were invited by the International Ladies' Garment Workers' Union for its 50th anniversary celebration in Atlantic City, New York. During the visit, they visited Union headquarters and connected with several people, who in Burk's words, "treated [them] like royalty."

They were featured in a news article about the trip in the *Forward Yiddish* newspaper. The article highlight helped Burk make connections with the Savage family, who were related to her father's sisters. With her brother married, and sister engaged, Burk immigrated to the United States in 1951 to live with the Savage family.

In 1971, she met Maurice Burk, who she would eventually marry. The Burkes moved to New Orleans, where they raised six children and had 14 grandchildren. In 1985, Burk traveled to the World Gathering of Holocaust Survivors in Philadelphia. At this gathering, Jeannine examined German records, which held her father's name, solidifying for her that he was never coming back.

Burk later participated in the Southern Institute's Holocaust education workshops and began participating in speaking engagements. She died in July 2020, but she remains in the hearts and minds of those who knew her and in the organizations with which she partnered.

To learn more about Jeannine Burk's life and other Holocaust survivors, follow the links below:

Holocaust Survivors
Jeannine's Biography - Teaching the Holocaust
Jeannine Burk | The National WWII Museum New Orleans (nationalww2museum.org)